



FIREFIGHTERS WORK on a home off Bollinger Drive in Pacific Palisades. “It’s like an inferno,” one resident said of the Palisades fire.

Fire rages in L.A. coastal enclave

Windstorm drives a fast-moving blaze in hilly Palisades, with cars trapped on roads.

By GRACE TOOHEY, NOAH HAGGERTY, NOAH GOLDBERG AND HANNAH FRY

A fire was burning out of control Tuesday in Pacific Palisades, destroying homes and forcing residents to abandon their vehicles and flee amid a potentially “life-threatening and destructive” windstorm.

Most of Pacific Palisades was under an evacuation order by the afternoon, as residents fought traffic jams and heavy smoke trying to escape the nearby flames. The Palisades fire broke out about 10:30 a.m. near Piedra Morada Drive and was pushed by intense wind gusts that officials had warned could turn any spark into a fast-moving and erratic wildfire. It was more than 1,200 acres as of Tuesday evening.

“It’s bad. It’s like an inferno,” said Lori Libonati, who lives in Pacific Palisades and saw the fire start to burn in the morning before evacuating.

The cause of the fire remains under investigation. Massive smoke plumes filled the sky in the area as families evacuated not far from hillsides glowing orange. The blaze quickly jumped across Palisades Drive, according to the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, leaving many people trying to evacuate in a precarious and chaotic situation. Some jumped out of their stalled cars to run toward the beach; others were forced to return home and shelter in place if they couldn’t get out, residents told The Times.

Ellen Delosh-Bacher tried to rush home from downtown Los Angeles when she heard about the fire to get her 95-year-old mother, her caregiver and their two dogs, but she quickly hit a standstill at Sunset Boulevard and Palisades Drive.

Then the fire exploded right along the road, and police officers started yelling for people to abandon their cars: “Run for your lives!” Delosh-Bacher recalled. She left her keys still in the ignition and ran the half-mile down to the beach. Firefighters could be heard telling dispatchers over radio traffic that as many as 100 abandoned vehicles were blocking the road.

“This is like an apocalypse,” Delosh-Bacher said. “I live on a ridge. I’m going to be pretty screwed if the fire goes up” there.

Her mother was stuck at her house, but she said she heard firefighters started telling her neighbors to shelter in place instead of evacuate.

“I don’t know, I’m so scared,” she said.

Capt. Erik Scott, a Los Angeles Fire Department spokesman, said that some homes had burned, but that a precise estimate was not immediately available.

Much of Southern California remains under severe red flag warnings as strong

State moves to help undocumented students

Bonta, LAUSD officials take action amid Trump’s threat of mass deportations.

By HOWARD BLUME AND OLIVIA SANCHEZ

California is moving quickly to protect undocumented immigrant students as top officials Monday outlined steps to guide school leaders, inform parents and provide mental health support to anxious students

and families at elementary schools through university campuses.

This deployment of reassurance and resources at public schools, where every child has a right to an education regardless of immigration status, is designed to counter President-elect Donald Trump, who takes office Jan. 20. Trump has repeatedly vowed to order mass deportations to address what he characterizes as the harms of illegal immigration.

The California pushback on Monday came from Los

Angeles Unified School District Supt. Alberto Carvalho on the first day of the spring semester and state Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta.

Carvalho highlighted mandatory upcoming training for employees about what assistance or documentation they cannot or should not provide to federal immigration authorities. The nation’s second-largest school system also will provide information cards to parents listing their rights.

The schools chief also promoted state-funded mental health support for

students that will be available online or by phone. It can be arranged in person through a school or online through the district’s “parent portal.”

“These are necessary steps for people who are members of our community, who are tax-paying members of our community, who are students in our environment, who are members of our workforce,” Carvalho said.

Bonta acted in a similar vein, releasing guidance for parents, in part stating that information about citi-

zenship or immigration status is never needed for school enrollment. A second document was prepared to help school districts comply with state law limiting state and local participation in immigration enforcement activities.

“You can be sure that if Trump attacks the rights of our immigrants, I will take action,” Bonta said.

“We’ve been preparing for weeks and for months [for] Trump’s latest plans for mass deportations and arrests, his claims that he’ll de-

[See Students, A7]

Mirroring X, Meta is ending its third-party fact-check program

By QUEENIE WONG

Facebook parent company Meta Platforms said Tuesday that it’s ending a third-party fact-checking program in the United States, a controversial move that will change how the social media giant combats misinformation.

Instead, Meta said it would lean on its users to write “community notes” on potentially misleading posts. Meta’s move toward crowd-sourcing its content moderation mirrors an approach taken by X, the social media platform owned by Elon Musk.

The decision by Meta sparked criticism from fact-checkers and advocacy groups, some of whom accused Chief Executive Mark

Zuckerberg of trying to cozy up to President-elect Donald Trump. Trump has often lashed out at Facebook and other social media sites for what he has said are their biases against him and right-leaning points of view.

Zuckerberg, through Meta, is among a group of tech billionaires and companies who donated \$1 million to Trump’s inaugural fund. This month, Meta also named Joel Kaplan, a prominent Republican lobbyist, as the new head of global policy. And Dana White, the chief executive of Ultimate Fighting Championship and a friend of Trump’s, is joining Meta’s board.

Content moderation on social media sites has become a political lightning rod with Republicans accus-

[See Meta, A9]



UC BERKELEY, above, with an undergraduate acceptance rate of 11%, saw a rise in Black and Latino admission rates, joining UCLA in bucking national trends.

In-state enrollment at UC campuses reaches new high

Berkeley, UCLA defy national trends with increased Black and Latino enrollment.

By JAWEED KALEEM

The University of California enrolled a record number of Californians in fall 2024, while UC Berkeley joined UCLA in bucking national trends at elite institutions that saw declines in new Black and Latino students in the first class since the U.S. Supreme Court

struck down affirmative action.

The data, made public Tuesday, came as the nine undergraduate campus system has faced intense ongoing public pressure to take in more Californians and amid speculation over how its racial makeup would fare in a state where public universities and colleges have long been banned from considering race and gender in admissions.

In total, 198,718 Californians were enrolled for the academic year that began in the fall at the system’s undergraduate campuses that

stretch from Davis to San Diego. California residents made up 84.2% of 236,070 undergraduates, compared to 83.5% the year before.

Among those were 60,644 first-year and transfer students from the state. The number of California residents in that category increased at six campuses. UC San Diego had the biggest jump, increasing from 8,436 to 8,907.

“The University of California is committed to expanding access and opportunity, helping our state’s brightest students from all

[See Enrollment, A12]

‘All hell will break out,’ Trump says

President-elect sounds off on the Mideast conflict, Gulf of Mexico and military use abroad. **NATION, A5**

Legal migration reverses ‘exodus’

A rise in foreign newcomers partly offsets relocations of state residents. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Sunny and breezy. L.A. Basin: 75/48. **B6**

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Experian sued by consumer bureau

Lawsuit accuses credit reporting firm of mishandling consumer disputes. **BUSINESS, A8**

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